

Lab: Philosophy of Mind and the Self-Model

Learning Goal: Apply philosophical analysis to Active Inference's account of selfhood, consciousness, and agency.

Part 1: The Self-Model Inventory

Exercise: Map different aspects of selfhood to the generative model framework:

Aspect of Self	Generative Model Component	Philosophical Tradition	Active Inference Formalization
Bodily self	Interoceptive model	Merleau-Ponty	
Narrative self	Higher-order temporal model	Ricoeur	
Minimal self	Basic self-model	Zahavi	
Social self	Model of others' models of me	Mead/Goffman	

For each, explain whether the mapping is illuminating or misleading. (500 words total)

Write your response here

Part 2: The Hard Problem Debate

Learning Goal: Evaluate competing positions on consciousness within the FEP framework.

Exercise: Consider three positions:

Position A (Optimist): "Active Inference will eventually explain consciousness because phenomenal experience just *is* the self-model in action."

Position B (Pessimist): "Active Inference explains the *structure* of experience but can never explain why there is something it's like. The hard problem remains."

Position C (Deflationist): "The hard problem is a pseudo-problem arising from confused concepts. Active Inference dissolves it by showing that 'experience' just means 'inference.'"

Write 150 words defending each position, then state which you find most compelling.

Write your response here

Part 3: The Agency Spectrum

Learning Goal: Apply the graduated ontology to real-world cases.

Exercise: Place each system on the agency spectrum and justify:

System	Level (1-4)	Justification
Rock sliding downhill		
Thermostat		
E. coli bacterium		
Mouse in a maze		
Human philosopher		
GPT-4 language model		

Where do you draw the line between "mere systems" and "genuine agents"? Is this line principled or arbitrary?

Write your response here

Part 4: Free Will Analysis

Learning Goal: Apply Active Inference to the free will debate.

Exercise:

1. Formalize "freedom" in Active Inference terms (acting from one's own model vs. external coercion).
2. Give an example of a "free" action and an "unfree" action in this framework.
3. Does this formalization capture what we ordinarily mean by "free will"? What's missing?

Write your response here

Part 5: Reflection

In 250 words, reflect: Does Active Inference offer a genuinely new philosophical account of the self, or does it merely formalize existing ideas (Hume, Metzinger, Buddhism) in mathematical notation? What would change in philosophy if the FEP account of selfhood were universally accepted?

Write your response here

Lab Summary

Part	Skill Practiced	Key Concept
1	Conceptual mapping	Self-model components
2	Dialectical analysis	Hard problem positions
3	Ontological classification	Agency spectrum
4	Conceptual analysis	Free will
5	Philosophical reflection	Novelty of FEP self